

Kelsey M. Vaughn

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Education

Ph.D. in Ecology

In progress

University of Georgia

Odum School of Ecology

Dr. Craig Osenberg's Lab

Dissertation: *Deciphering Predator-Prey Interactions: Predator Characteristics, Cognitive Plasticity, and Environmental Influences on Behavior*

GPA: 3.82

Master of Science

December 2021

University of the Virgin Islands, St. Thomas, USVI

College of Science and Mathematics

Department of Biological Sciences

Focus in Marine and Environmental Science

Thesis: *Assessment of the ability of the invasive species Halophila stipulacea to store sediment carbon in nearshore habitats of St. Thomas, U.S. Virgin Islands*

GPA: 3.71

Bachelor of Science

May 2019

University of Arkansas, Fayetteville, AR

Dale Bumper's College

Major: Animal Science

Concentration: Equine Science

Work Experience

Instructor of Record

January 2026-present

University of Georgia

Supervisor: Dr. Brittany Ferrari, baferrari@uga.edu

Instructor of record for Ecology laboratory.

Research Assistant

May-December 2025

University of Georgia

Supervisor: Dr. Mark Hunter, mdhunter@uga.edu

Led all phases of an agrivoltaics research project, designing and implementing pre- and post-development biodiversity and soil health assessments, including field sampling, data management, and analysis to evaluate ecosystem impacts of solar infrastructure.

Instructor of Record

August 2023-May 2025

*University of Georgia*Supervisor: Dr. Brittany Ferrari, baferrari@uga.edu

Instructor of record for Ecology laboratory. Voluntarily assisted in the redevelopment of course materials.

Research Assistant

January 2023-July 2023

*University of Georgia*Supervisor: Dr. Craig Osenberg, osenberg@uga.edu

Created and implemented website content in RMarkdown

Instructor of Record

August 2022-December 2022

*University of Georgia*Supervisor: Dr. Kait Farrell, kfarrell@uga.edu

Instructor of record for Ecology laboratory

Field Assistant

November 2022-May 2024

*University of Georgia*Supervisor: Dr. James Porter, jporter@uga.edu

Conduct fieldwork for long-term white-pox monitoring on Horseshoe reef in Key Largo, Florida

Research Assistant

May 2022-August 2022

*University of Georgia*Supervisor: Dr. Craig Osenberg, osenberg@uga.edu

Project: Coral size-specific growth in the presence and absence of predators

Instructor of Record

August 2019-December 2019

*University of the Virgin Islands*Supervisor: Dr. Ewin Cruz-Rivera edwin.cruz-rivera@morgan.edu Instructor of record for Ecology laboratory**Grant and Scholarship Awards**

Frank Golley Memorial Scholarship	2026
Spencer Small Grant Program	2026
Science Foundation – Whatlfs Grant	2026
Odum School of Ecology Travel Grant	2025
UGA Graduate School Summer Research Grant	2025
Odum School of Ecology Large Grant	2025
Odum School of Ecology Large Grant	2024
Odum School of Ecology Large Grant	2023
Odum School of Ecology Travel Grant	2023
School Travel Grant - University of Georgia	2023
Scholarship in Science, Technology, Engineering, and Mathematics (S-STEM)	2020-2021
MMES Lana Vento Charitable Trust Award	2021
MMES Lana Vento Charitable Trust Award	2021
MMES Lana Vento Charitable Trust Award	2020

Professional Organizations

Georgia Chapter of the American Fisheries Society	2025
Sigma Xi	2024-present
Association for the Sciences of Limnology and Oceanography	2021-present
Coastal and Estuarine Research Federation	2020-present

Professional Development

Communication Series: 1) Professional Identity Formation	March 2026
Communication Series: 2) Concrete Images and Telling a Story	
Communication Series: 3) How to Connect Through (Shared) Writing	
Odum School of Ecology	
How to Operationalize Human Dimensions Concepts	February 2026
World Recreational Fisheries Conference	
<i>Learned framing and utilization of Structured Equation Models</i>	
Teaching Philosophy Statement Workshop	April 2025
Odum School of Ecology - UGA	
<i>Begin drafting application materials</i>	
Documenting Your Teaching Workshop	March 2025
Odum School of Ecology - UGA	
<i>Reflecting and collecting evidence of teaching for teaching portfolios</i>	
Graduate Teaching Certificate (UGA)	Completed 2025
Lerner-Centered Teaching	September 2024
UGA GradTeach Program Workshop	
<i>Learned strategies for designing courses and assessments aligned with learning objectives</i>	
How Learning Works	August 2024
UGA GradTeach Program Workshop	
<i>Learned how to build working knowledge on how to support students</i>	
DEI Workshop: Five Shifts in Research and Teaching Practices Towards a More Inclusive and Ethical Ecology	April 2023
Odum School of Ecology – UGA	
<i>Discussed decoloniality and anti-oppressive practices for a more ethical ecology</i>	
Metacognition: Helping Students Monitor Their Own Learning	January 2023
UGA GradTeach Program	
<i>Learned about theories of metacognition in relation to learning</i>	

Service and Mentorship

Undergraduate Research Mentor	2022-present
<i>Mentored 16 undergraduate researchers: 4 CURO scholars (independent research projects), 4 Directed Research credit students, and 8 volunteer research assistants</i>	
Reviewer for Biological Bulletin	
Graduate Student Organization President (UGA)	2023-present
Graduate Student Symposium Chair (UGA)	2023-2024

Odum School of Ecology Awards Banquet Chair (UGA)	2023
University of Georgia GIS Day Co-Chair (UGA)	2023
New Student Orientation Planning Committee (UGA)	2023-2024
EcoReach (UGA)	2023-present
Graduate Student Representative (UVI)	2019-2020

Presentations

2026 World Recreational Fisheries Conference

Warming Waters and Shifting Behaviors: Cognitive Limits and Species Interactions in a Recreational Fishery Under Climate Stress

2025 Graduate Student Symposium

Effects of Temperature on the cognitive performance of an aquatic predator and prey

2024 Benthic Ecology Meeting

Effects of predator hunting–strategy on foraging behavior of coral reef fishes

2024 World Fisheries Congress

Effects of predator hunting–strategy on foraging behavior of coral reef fishes

2024 Graduate Student Symposium

Effects of predator hunting–strategy on foraging behavior of coral reef fishes

2023 Graduate Student Symposium

Size-specific coral growth in the presence and absence of predators

2021 Coastal and Estuarine Research Federation (CERF)

Impacts of water depth on sediment carbon density in *Halophila stipulacea* beds in St. Thomas, USVI

2020 Global Conference on Global Warming (GCGW) Conference

Stony Coral Tissue Loss Disease and the Impacts of its Spread on Coral Reef Species Diversity in the US Virgin Island

2020 Stony Coral Tissue Loss Webinar

Stony Coral Tissue Loss Disease in the USVI and the Ecological Consequences of its Spread

2020 SACNAS virtual conference

Stony Coral Tissue Loss Disease and the Impacts of its Spread on Coral Reef Species Diversity in the US Virgin Island

Publications

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- Ayad, M., Lee C., Porter, J., Chirayath, V., Nivison, C., **Vaughn , K. M.**, Kudela, R. (2025) Impacts of the 2023 Marine Heatwave in the Florida Keys: Detection and Analysis of a Mass Coral Bleaching Event Using Spaceborne Remote Sensing Imagery. *JGR Oceans*.
- Cryan, D. M., **Vaughn, K. M.**, & Caves, E. M. (2024). Nocturnal Cleaning Interactions Between the Giant Moray (*Gymnothorax javanicus*) and the Clear Cleaner Shrimp (*Urocaridella antonbruunii*). *Ecology and Evolution*, 14(12), e70589.
- Vaughn, K. M.**, Durdall, A., Willette, D. A., Brandt, M., Costa, S., & Grimes, K. W. (2024). Sediment carbon storage in subtidal beds of the invasive seagrass *Halophila stipulacea* along an extreme water depth gradient, St. Thomas, US Virgin Islands. *Aquatic Botany*, 194, 103778.

- Costa, S. V., Habtes, S., Willette, D., Budd, K. A., Kadison, E., **Vaughn, K. M.**, & Nemeth, R. S. (2024). Impact of invasive seagrass *Halophila stipulacea* on life history characteristics of juvenile yellowtail snapper (*Ocyurus chrysurus*). *Bulletin of Marine Science*.
- Costa, S.V., Hibberts, S.J., Olive, D.A., Budd, K.A., Long, A.E., Meiling, S.S., Miller, M.B., **Vaughn, K.M.**, Carrión, C.I., Cohen, M.B., Savage, A.E., Souza, M.F., Buckley, L. Grimes, K.W., Platenberg, R., Smith, T.B., Blondeau, J., Brandt, M.E. (2021) Diversity and Disease: The effects of coral diversity on prevalence and impacts of stony coral tissue loss disease in Saint Thomas, U.S. Virgin Islands. *Frontiers in marine science*, 8, 682688.

References available upon request